

"Don't waste your life," warns Brian, but this bleak movie ends as it began, with Johnny on the move, in the process of doing just that. Director Mike Leigh uses a long rehearsal process with his actors to develop characters and scripts for his movies, and in *Naked*, he provoked a stunning performance from Thewlis—egoistic, bitter, and nihilistic, yet funny and endearing at times.

SHORT CUTS

Robert Altman, 1993

Based on nine short stories by Raymond Carver, Robert Altman's *Short Cuts* follows the fortunes of 22 ordinary people in Los Angeles as their lives interweave over a few days. The people, played by an all-star cast that includes Jack Lemmon and Julianne Moore, have little in common, and do nothing especially dramatic, but beneath their lives is a sense of insecurity and unease about the future, symbolized by a plague of flies and earthquake warnings. Altman creates a sense of something heroic in their willingness to keep trying, hoping for something better.

HEAVENLY CREATURES

Peter Jackson, 1994

After an early career making low-budget splatter movies, Peter Jackson had a dramatic change of direction with this touching movie based on a true story about a murder in Christchurch, New Zealand. Two misfit teenagers, rich English girl Juliet (Kate Winslet) and shy New Zealander Pauline (Melanie Lynskey), develop an intense relationship and decide to

kill Pauline's mother when she tries to keep them apart. As the girls blur the line between reality and the fantasy world they create with stories, pictures, and plastic figurines, so does Jackson, creating a movie that deals with a grim story in a surprisingly uplifting way.

See also: *The Lord of the Rings: The Fellowship of the Ring* 302–03

DRIFTING CLOUDS

Aki Kaurismäki, 1996

Drifting Clouds, by Finnish director Aki Kaurismäki, is a wry, tender look at the lives of an ordinary couple brought low by a recession. Ilona (Kati Outinen) works in a restaurant and her husband Lauri (Kari Väänänen) is a bus driver. The couple scrape by until both lose their jobs. Lauri loses his licence for medical reasons, and although Ilona finds a new restaurant job, she is cheated out of her wages. It ends ambiguously, but hopefully, with the couple opening a restaurant and seeing it fill with customers.

BREAKING THE WAVES

Lars von Trier, 1996

Set in a remote part of Scotland in the 1970s, *Breaking the Waves* is the strange story of Bess (Emily Watson). Deeply religious and naive, Bess begins to come out of her shell when she impulsively marries Swedish oil rig worker Jan (Stellan Skarsgård). Things change dramatically when Jan is paralyzed in a rig accident. He tells her that they can still have a sex life—by proxy—if she will sleep with other men and describe for him her acts. Bess debases herself sexually with other men, believing that by doing

so, God will cure Jan. Scandalized, her local church casts her out, but when, at the end, she sacrifices her life, Jan is apparently cured.

TASTE OF CHERRY

Abbas Kiarostami, 1997

Taste of Cherry, by Iranian director Abbas Kiarostami, is a minimalist movie about a man who drives around Tehran, looking for someone who will bury him once he has killed himself. We never find out why he wants to die. As he drives he picks up various candidates. Kiarostami had no script, but improvised the dialogue almost as a series of interviews, either from the man's point of view or that of his passenger. The end, in which the man is seen waiting for death in his grave, is surprisingly uplifting.

WERCKMEISTER HARMONIES

Béla Tarr, 2000

The Hungarian movie *Werckmeister Harmonies* consists of just 39 long shots in black and white, each a complete scene in itself. The story is set in a bleak town in winter. A circus arrives, and a stuffed whale is its main attraction. The story is seen through the eyes of the wise fool János (Lars Randolph). János looks after György (Peter Fitz), who believes the world's problems began with the musical theories of 17th-century organist Andreas Werckmeister. It may be an allegory for Communist-era Hungary. Its target could also be capitalism or totalitarianism; either way, its view of humanity is pessimistic, showing acts of collective brutality committed for no clear reason.